

China Metals Activity Tracker

China high frequency data implies higher rates of copper & aluminium consumption in June-July; China copper premium hit \$100/t last week



We present our high-frequency inventory trends for base metals and iron ore in China for the week ended 17 Jul'26. Our data plots China weekly metals inventory trends, a proxy for consumption. **Copper** saw another 17kt drawdown last week with visible inventory in China now down to ~120kt, 30kt below the low level we saw in 2025. End of last week, Yangshan Copper Premium hit \$100/t mark which was last reached in May'25. **Aluminium**'s strong destocking also continued, with total visible inventory now back to ~1Mt. JPM Commodities Research forecast a sizeable 3Q ex-China deficit that will likely pull LME pricing higher to attract metals into the global market from China ([link](#)).

JPM Commodities Research published a China demand monitor based on detailed data available to 5M'26 ([link](#)). Our colleagues note that consumption-weighted end-use for China **Copper** demand fell -5% YoY in 5M'26, but apparent consumption was +8% yoy in May. However in the case of both Copper and Aluminium, these weak demand datapoints represent the period 5M'26 which is consistent with our previous high frequency data assessment of weak de-stocking indicators in the month of May. Our high frequency data tracker implies strengthening in copper and aluminium consumption in June-July, as shown in the charts below.

China Q2 economic releases last week showed Q2 real GDP slowed to 4.3% YoY, from 5.0% in 1Q; manufacturing was resilient but FAI contracted significantly. Latest loan growth data for June also showed material weakness, with TSF growth slowing by 0.3% pts to a record low of 7.4% ([link](#) / [link](#)).

Within EMEA Miners, our favoured name remains **Antofagasta** ([link](#)) as we see the copper price support to generate FCF inflection and an inexpensive valuation on a 2028E basis driven by >30% brownfield growth. We are **Neutral on BHP and RIO** London listings and are **UW on Anglo American** taking into account of cost inflation risk at its Iron Ore division and potential weak Diamonds division result in H1'26 ([link](#)).

We provide our latest EMEA Metals & Mining valuations and commodity price scenario analysis ([here](#)).

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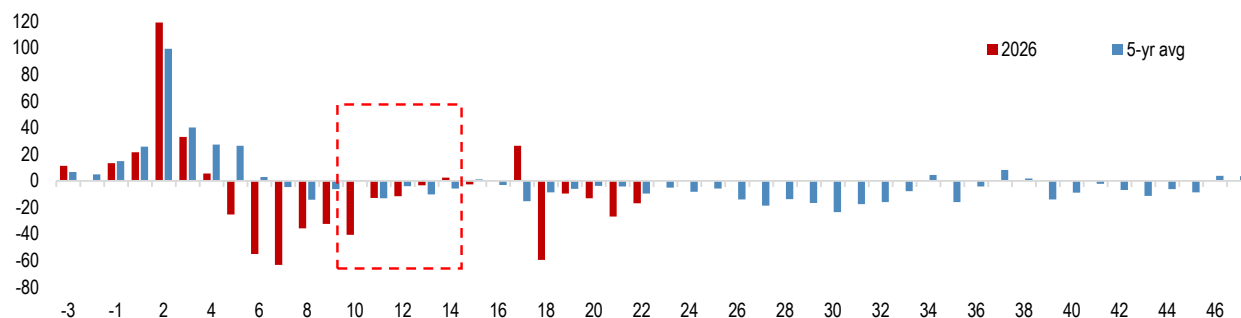
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Figure 1: Weekly change in China visible copper inventory (SHFE + Bonded). Red box shows May period covered by JPM Commodities Research, Jun-July appear to show a pick up in consumption

x-axis = weeks post Chinese New Year (week 0 = week closest to start of CNY), y-axis = kt of copper increase / (decrease)

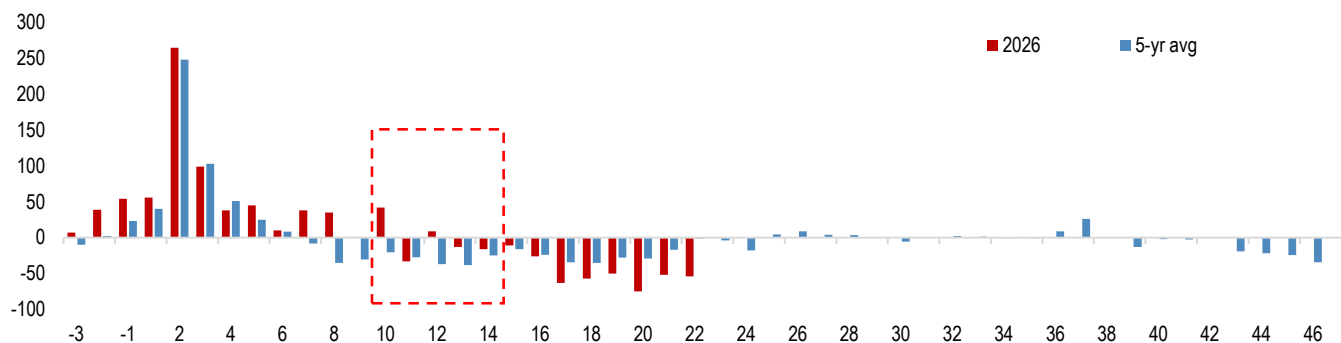


*Build over first and second weeks post-CNY averaged due to lagged inventory reporting.

Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities, *First and second weeks grouped together due to lagged inventory reporting

Figure 2: Aluminum inventories movements in 2026 – weekly change in China visible aluminium inventory (SHFE + Bonded). 52kt of Aluminium destocking in the past week, strongest since 2026 CNY

x-axis = weeks post Chinese New Year (week 0 = week closest to start of CNY), y-axis = kt of aluminium increase / (decrease)



*Build over first and second weeks post-CNY averaged due to lagged inventory reporting.

Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities, *First and second weeks grouped together due to lagged inventory reporting

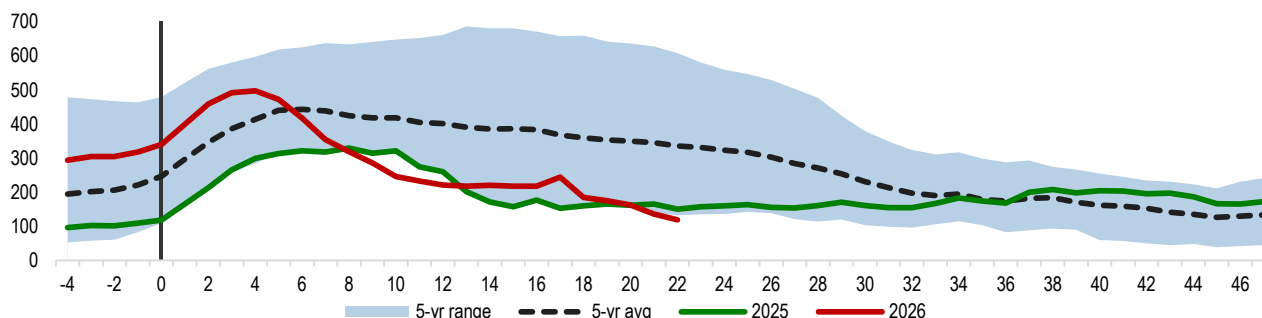
China metals inventory channel check – week ended 17 July 2026

J.P. Morgan is tracking China's metal inventories for potential insights regarding end-consumer demand activity. These high-frequency datapoints provide signals to gauge China metals consumption trends. Rapid pivots in inventory de-stocking volumes (or re-stocking) can potentially provide signals that downstream consumption is improving (or weakening).

We are into the fifth week of seeing strong de-stocking in both **Copper** and **Aluminium**. Copper inventory saw another 17kt drawdown in the past week, bringing total visible copper inventory in China down to ~120kt. Aluminium also continued the strong de-stocking momentum with another drawdown of 54kt last week. Inventory level is now back to ~1Mt. **Zinc** however, saw re-stocking. Total onshore Zinc inventory is at 268kt, which is >130kt higher vs 5-year historical average at this time of the year.

Figure 3: Total China visible copper inventory (SHFE + Bonded) week ended 17 Jul'26. Copper inventory (119kt) tightest in the past decade during this time of the year; Inventory level sits 30kt below 2025 low

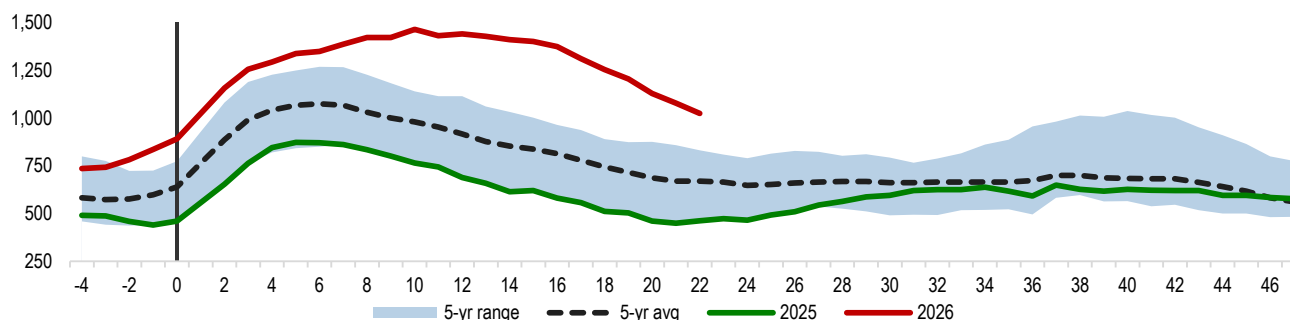
x-axis = weeks post Chinese New Year (week 0 = week closest to start of CNY), y-axis = kt of copper



Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities

Figure 4: Total China visible aluminum inventory (SHFE + Regional Warehouses) week ended 17 Jul'26. China aluminum inventory (1.0Mt) begins to fall due to stronger drawdowns in the past few weeks

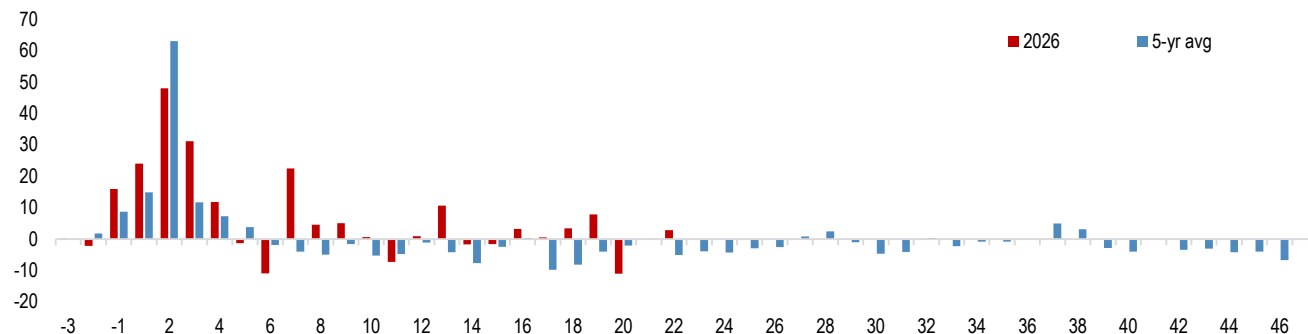
x-axis = weeks post Chinese New Year (week 0 = week closest to start of CNY), y-axis = kt of aluminium



Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities

Figure 5: Zinc inventories movements in 2026 – weekly change in China visible zinc inventory (SHFE + Bonded). Zinc restocking of 3kt in the past week

x-axis = weeks post Chinese New Year (week 0 = week closest to start of CNY), y-axis = kt of aluminium increase / (decrease)

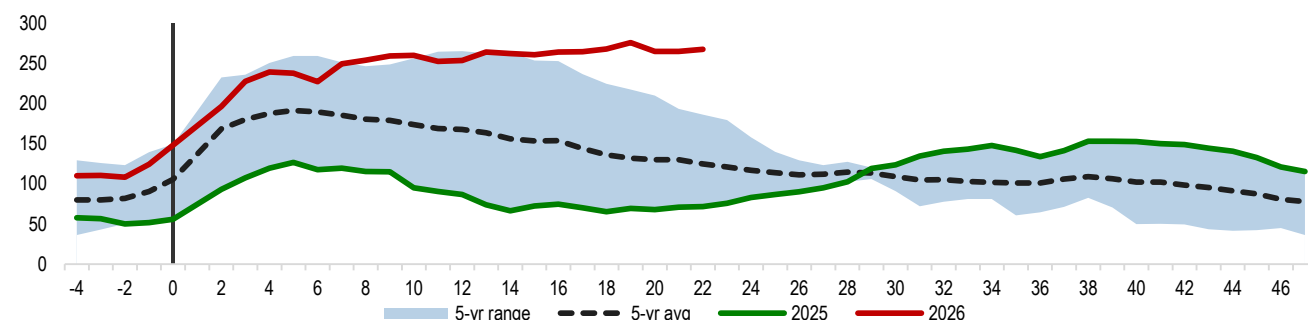


*Build over first and second weeks post-CNY averaged due to lagged inventory reporting.

Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities, *First and second weeks grouped together due to lagged inventory reporting

Figure 6: Total China visible zinc inventory for week ended 17 Jul'26. Total inventory (268kt) remains at the highest level since 2022

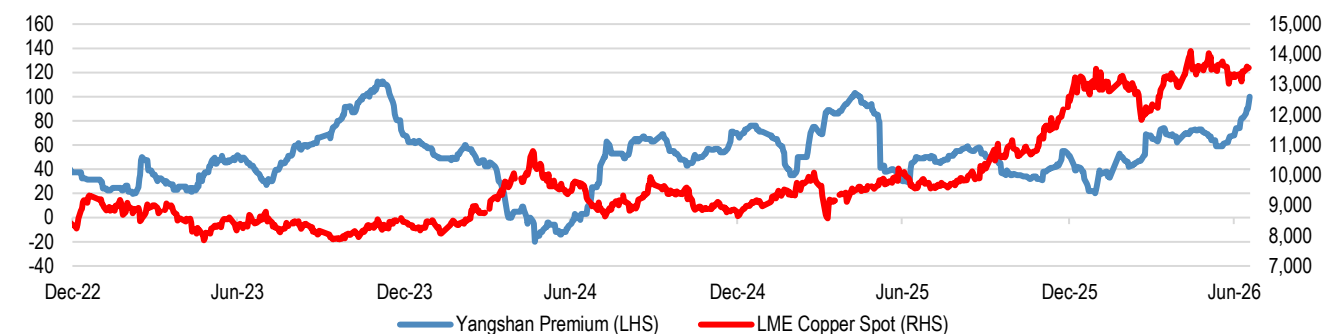
x-axis = weeks post Chinese New Year (week 0 = week closest to start of CNY), y-axis = kt of zinc



Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities Research

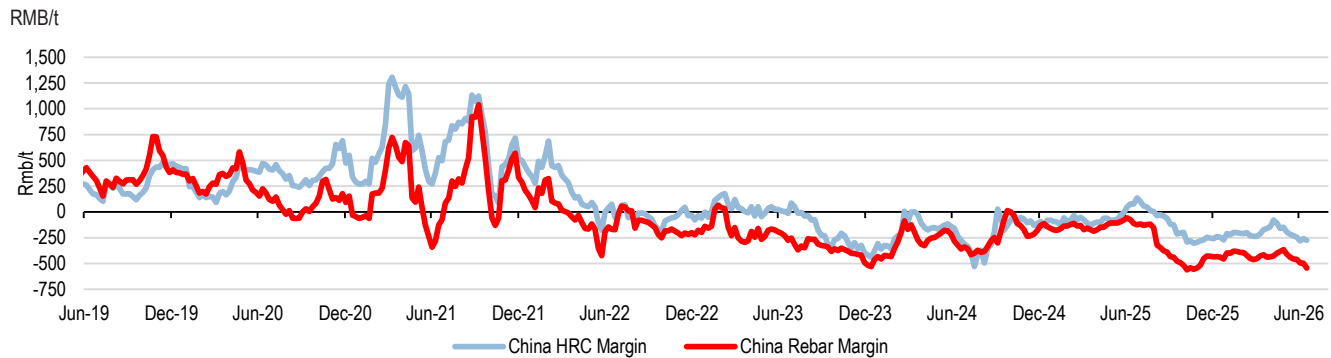
Figure 7: China Yangshan Copper Premium vs LME Copper Spot: Strong physical market demand brings premium to \$100/t

LHS: Yangshan Premium; RHS: LME Copper Spot; Unit: \$/t



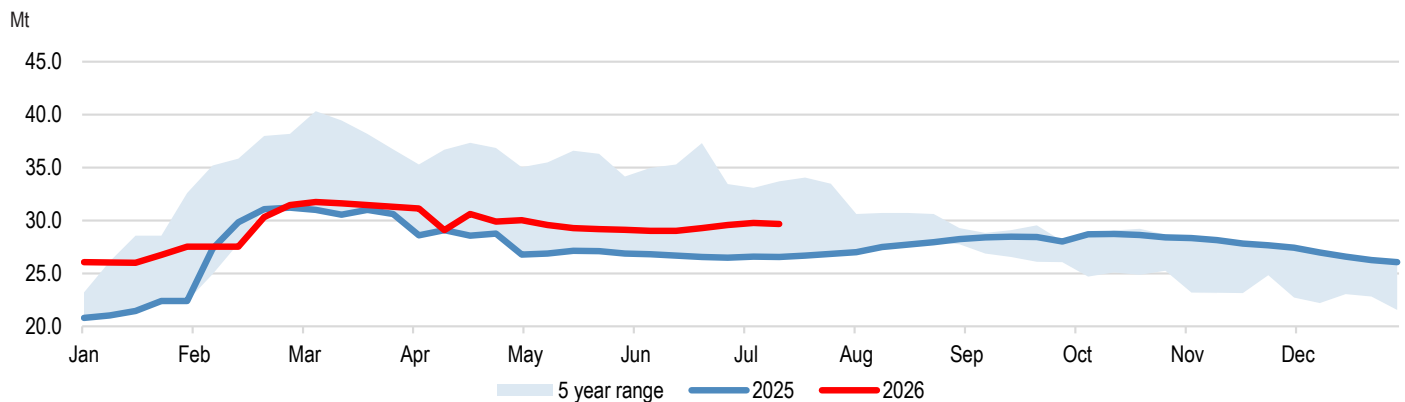
Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 8: China steel mill margins extend losses driven by higher coking coal prices



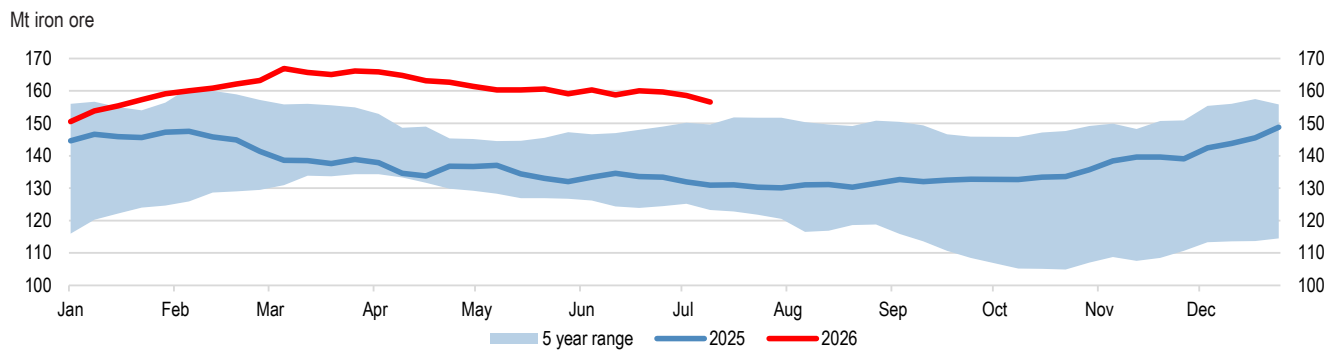
Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., J.P. Morgan estimates.

Figure 9: China steel inventory week ending 17 Jul, flat WoW and +12% YoY; Inventory has picked up since June



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

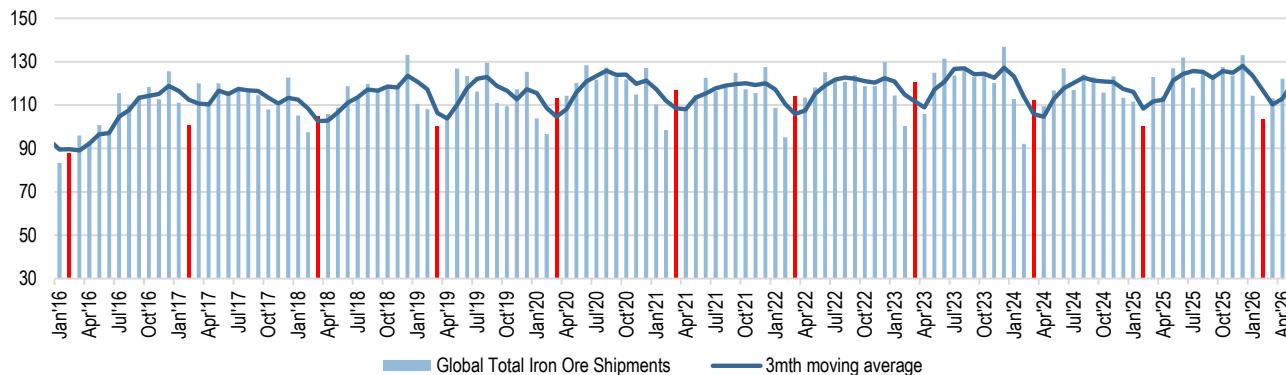
Figure 10: Iron Ore inventory saw ~3Mt drawdown in the past week after flat inventory for ~9 weeks



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 11: Global iron ore shipments - Global shipments +2% MoM in May & -2% YoY

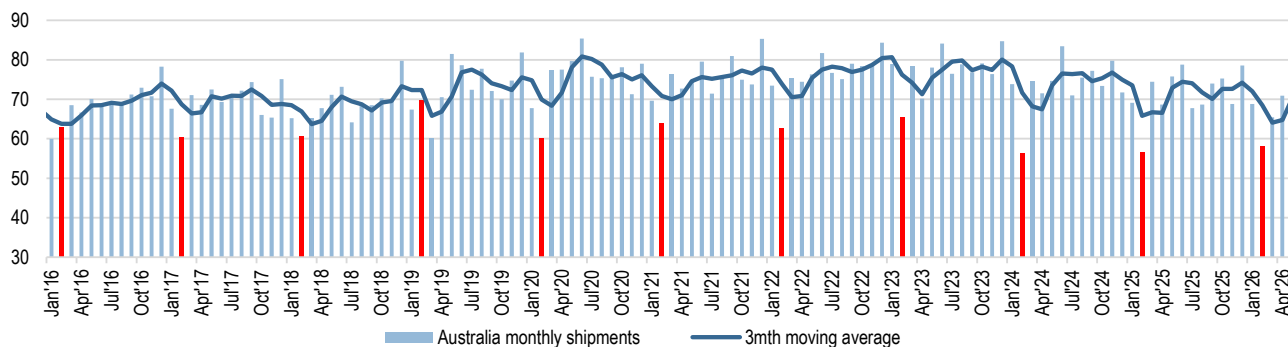
Mt iron ore exports, red bar = February, typical seasonal trough for shipments is Jan/Feb



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 12: Australia iron ore shipments - Latest data suggests Australian iron ore shipments +5% MoM in May & -2% YoY

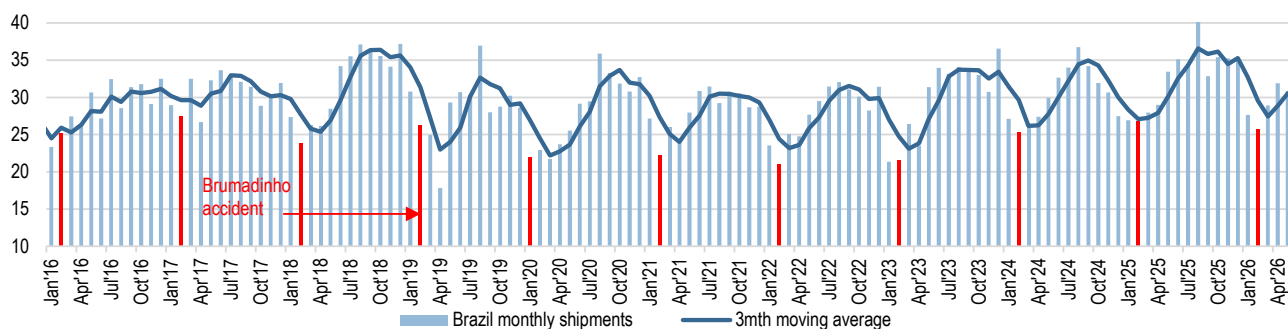
Mt iron ore exports, red bar = February, typical seasonal trough for shipments is Jan/Feb



Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

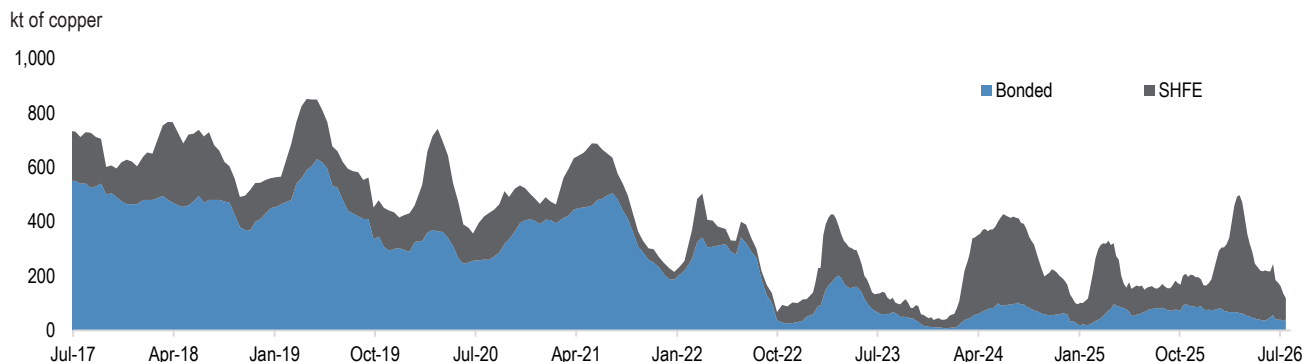
Figure 13: Brazil iron ore shipments -3% MoM in May, -8% YoY

Mt iron ore exports, red bar = February, typical seasonal trough for shipments is Jan/Feb



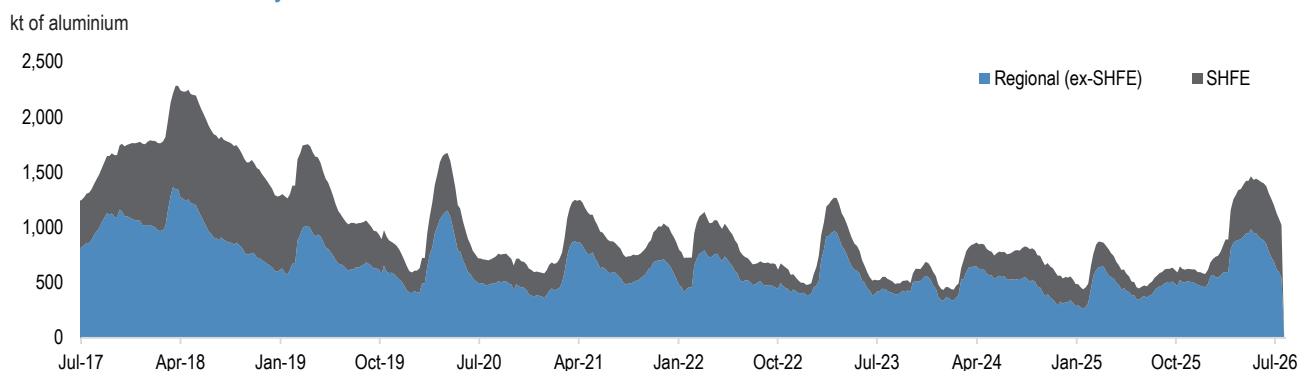
Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, Bloomberg Finance L.P.

Figure 14: Chinese visible copper inventory (SHFE + Bonded) for week ended 17 Jul. Copper inventories lower in the past week due to significant inventory draw



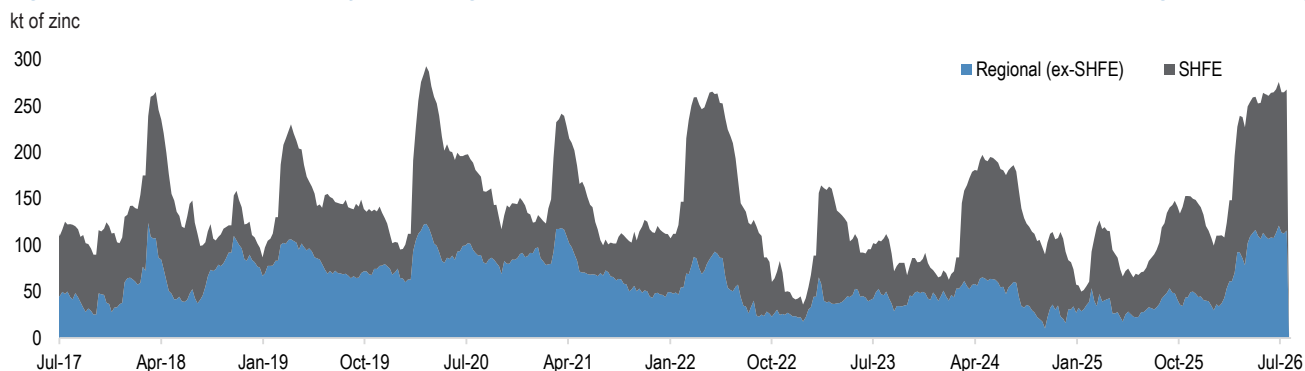
Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities

Figure 15: China visible aluminium inventory (SHFE + Regional Warehouses) for week ended 17 Jul. Destocking in the past few weeks has significantly reduced aluminium inventory



Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities Research

Figure 16: China visible zinc inventory (SHFE + Regional Warehouses) for week ended 17 Jul. Zinc inventories are still at the highest level vs 5-year range



Source: SHFE, CRU, SMM, J.P. Morgan Commodities

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